

Checklist:

Team Culture Checklist

Understand your current team

- ☐ Write down the first 3 adjectives that describe your team's personality.
- ☐ Identify the moments that made you most proud to be part of the team.
- ☐ Note what your team does better than most other teams.
- ☐ Ask: if random team members were asked, "What does our team value?", would their answers be consistent?
- ☐ Compare your team's culture with the broader organization's culture.
- ☐ Imagine an outside observer scrutinizing your team. What would they say the team does well or poorly?
- ☐ List the top 3 complaints people have about how things work.

Clarify your aspirations

- ☐ Choose the top 5 adjectives you want others to use to describe your team.
- ☐ For each adjective, identify the downside or tradeoff of taking it too far.
- ☐ List cultural traits you admire in other teams or organizations.
- ☐ Note why you admire them and what tradeoffs those teams accept.
- ☐ List the cultural traits you do not want to copy from other teams or companies.

Understand the gap

- ☐ Rate your team from 1-9 on how close it is to your ideal culture.
- ☐ Identify the strengths your team already has that align with your desired culture.
- ☐ List the biggest gaps between the current culture and the desired culture.
- ☐ Identify the main obstacles that could block progress.
- ☐ Describe how you want your team to work one year from now.

Keep talking about what matters

- ☐ Repeatedly communicate the values and behaviors that matter most.
- ☐ Use multiple channels to reinforce the same message.

- ☐ Encourage open discussion of tension, disagreement, and hard conversations.
- ☐ Assume important messages need to be heard many times in many forms.
- ☐ Talk openly not just about values, but also about mistakes and lessons learned.

Walk the walk

- ☐ Check whether your behavior matches the values you say matter.
- ☐ Eliminate visible contradictions between what you say and what you do.
- ☐ Model the exact behavior you want the team to adopt.
- ☐ Ask for feedback in the same way you expect others to.
- ☐ Treat trust as fragile and protect it through consistency.

Create the right incentives

- ☐ Review what behaviors are actually rewarded on the team.
- ☐ Compare stated values with the decisions people are incentivized to make.
- ☐ Watch for incentive traps such as:
 - ☐ rewarding individual performance over team success
 - ☐ rewarding short-term gains over long-term investments
 - ☐ rewarding avoidance of conflict over honest discussion
 - ☐ rewarding the loudest complainers
- ☐ Ask why people are making the choices they are making.
- ☐ Change structural incentives when they push people away from team values.
- ☐ Hold people accountable when their behavior violates team values.
- ☐ Publicly recognize people who do the hard right thing.

Build traditions that reinforce values

- ☐ Create rituals that help team members bond around shared values.
- ☐ Make those rituals specific to your team rather than generic.
- ☐ Add recurring moments that celebrate learning, openness, creativity, or support.
- ☐ Use traditions to make values visible in everyday team life.
- ☐ Pay attention to the small repeated actions that signal what matters.

Final reflection

- ☐ Review what your actions, rewards, and rituals are teaching the team.
- ☐ Make sure daily behavior tells the same story as your stated values.
- ☐ Adjust until your culture reflects what you genuinely want your team to become.